

Invisible Gorilla Discussion Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and the Knower • 20-25 min

Category	Knowledge and the Knower	Time	20-25 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	invisible-gorilla-discussion

Big idea: Attention is not a neutral spotlight; it decides which evidence enters awareness.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Invisible Gorilla Discussion Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Invisible Gorilla Discussion Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Counting task: students count how many times a blue card is passed while a student in a bright scarf crosses the room. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Invisible Gorilla Discussion Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Desk task: students count red objects in a photo while a large background detail changes between views. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Invisible Gorilla Discussion Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Desk task: students count red objects in a photo while a large background detail changes between views. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Attention is not a neutral spotlight; it decides which evidence enters awareness.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Invisible Gorilla Discussion Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Invisible Gorilla Discussion Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	How does attention shape what counts as evidence?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Counting task: students count how many times a blue card is passed while a student in a bright scarf crosses the room.
- Desk task: students count red objects in a photo while a large background detail changes between views.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and the Knower.

Activity Steps

1. Give students one narrow observation task, such as counting passes or repeated actions.
2. Run the short stimulus once without interruption.
3. Ask students to record the target count and anything unusual they noticed.
4. Reveal the unexpected element and compare what students missed.
5. Debrief how task, expectation, and confidence shaped what became evidence.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: How does attention shape what counts as evidence?
- Can missing evidence be a rational consequence of focusing well?
- Where might expert attention improve knowledge and where might it narrow knowledge?

Knowledge Questions

- How does attention shape what counts as evidence?
- To what extent is perception guided by expectation?
- Can expertise create blind spots as well as insight?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with a selective attention video or teacher-made counting task. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...